A Moment on the White Expanse

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A Mission

COL-312101

A Mission

At the world's end, upon the oldest, most merciless icefield, a blizzard blinds all onlookers.

Even the soldier's eagle eyes can make out nothing through the Antarctic storm, and so he turns back.

Former Zeno Sentinel Unit Station

Sergeant White Gloves: Lieutenant, how much time do we have?

Scribbles on paper resonate amid the whipping snow.

Moldir: 27 hours.

Moldir: Andrea's team traveled light to cover more ground. They will have minimal supplies.

Moldir: Factoring in exposure, terrain, and unconfirmed hostiles, Andrea's team has a golden window of 36 hours for rescue at best.

Moldir: It's been nine hours since they were expected back.

She finishes her calculations and shuts the notebook.

Moldir: Andrea is more than capable, but David ... He's still too young and raw for this.

Moldir: The admiral would never allow even a single child to be left behind.

Moldir: Three teams of three. That's all we can spare right now. Let's not waste another minute.

Moldir: Please assist me with the preparations, Sergeant.

Sergeant White Gloves: Yes, Lieutenant!

He glances outside. Pellets of blistering snow are still hammering the tent. Given enough time, they'll bury any trace of it.

Sergeant White Gloves: When do we move out?

Moldir: Factoring in the round-trip time for the rescue, we will have to leave within three hours.

Moldir: If the storm lets up in that window, we head out immediately.

Moldir also turns to look outside, eyes steady as she stares down her enemy. There is no strategy to defeat it; the only option is to withstand the onslaught.

Moldir: If the weather stays against us, we'll use these three hours to prepare and adjust our strategy.

Moldir: But in three hours, we move. No matter the circumstances.

Luck is on their side. 1 hour and 27 minutes later, their enemy at last relents.

The blizzard has stopped.

Moldir: You've got ten minutes to gear up. Stick to the assigned supply splits—no changes.

Soldier I: Yes, Lieutenant!

Moldir: Listen carefully. Whether or not we find Andrea's team, you follow your orders to the letter.

Moldir: No exceeding your assigned search time. No straying from your team's designated path.

Moldir: I will be waiting at the rendezvous point.

She scans her small force, her eyes sweeping over each soldier.

Moldir: Every single one of you.

20 hours after Andrea's team went missing.

Moldir: We can't go any farther. Turn back and head for the rendezvous point.

Soldier I: But Lieutenant, we haven't reached our target location yet.

Moldir: If weather conditions turn, we scale back. That was in the mission briefing. We all agreed.

Soldier II: Lieutenant, with respect, we can keep going!

She admits a slight grin, admiring the grit of her soldiers, but shakes her head.

Moldir: Stick to the plan. End of discussion. Turn back and head for the rendezvous point.

Soldier I: But ...

Moldir: Out here, with supplies split across the team, breaking protocol puts lives at risk. That is not a gamble I'll allow.

Her tone sharpens, each word carrying weight.

Moldir: Follow your orders, soldier.

Soldier I: Yes, Lieutenant!

Moldir surveys the deepening snow once again, then leads the team back.

Her face is cold and still, but the Antarctic wind steals a quiet, frost-white sigh.

A Mission

COL-312102

All nine expedition members regroup at the rendezvous point and swiftly begin setting up their temporary outpost.

Moldir: Yes. Understood.

Moldir: Yes.

Moldir: I will continue the search, so long as it doesn't cost us any more lives.

Moldir: Yes, sir.

She ends the call with High Command and lowers the radio hesitantly. A small gesture signals to the sergeant that he can begin his report.

Sergeant White Gloves: According to the original briefing, we are to rest here for six hours, then begin our search operation again radially from this location.

Sergeant White Gloves: Lieutenant, speaking freely, that seems too long. Aren't we running out of time?

Moldir checks her watch.

Moldir: If we keep going without rest, we'll put our teams at risk. We cannot afford more casualties.

Sergeant White Gloves: It's been 24 hours since they went dark, Lieutenant.

Sergeant White Gloves: Our rescue window is dwindling. How much time does that leave them?

Moldir's lashes flicker.

Moldir: If we rest the full six? 42.

Moldir: The outer limit for survival in these conditions is 72 hours, Sergeant.

Moldir: That team is like forged steel. Andrea will keep them safe. I believe in them.

Sergeant White Gloves: Then I believe in them too, Lieutenant.

Moldir: Good. Get something to eat and rest up while you can, Sergeant.

Sergeant White Gloves: Yes, Lieutenant.

Moldir: I'll double-check tomorrow's route and timing. If conditions allow, we'll widen the search range as far as we can.

Sergeant White Gloves: Understood.

Sergeant White Gloves: Try to rest too, Lieutenant.

Moldir: Thank you for your concern, Sergeant. I won't go against the protocols I set myself.

It has now been 25 hours since Andrea's team went missing.

An hour has passed, and Moldir still hasn't slept.

The military map spread across a wooden crate bears layers of markings. In front of each hand-drawn arrow is a looming dark hand.

Moldir: ...

Moldir: We need full coverage, but we can't afford a direct clash with them.

Moldir: This is a crucial phase in the admiral's negotiations ...

She falls into a long silence and drifts her hand toward a photo. David, in his Zeno Corps uniform, grins brightly, looking in every way like a fresh-faced cadet.

Just beneath her fingertip, a sliver of orange peeks out from the photo's edge. Her eyes fix on it.

She flips the photo over and slips it back into the safest place she can think of.

A sharp sound pulls her attention.

Moldir: Who's there?!

Before her eyes, something swells outward from a quiet stretch of snow.

???: Ah! Ow!

Penguins: Wawk, wawk—

???: Ugh, my noggin's hurtin' somethin' fierce. Hey, pals, where are we?

Penguins: Moldir blinks incredulously.

Penguins: Three penguins. Adélie penguins—natives of Antarctica. And standing in front of them, returning her stare with a cautious look—

Moldir: A squirrel?

An Encounter

COL-312103

An Encounter

In the dead of night, the lieutenant stands inside her tent, weapon in hand, facing off against these bizarre intruders.

She can't afford to lower her guard just because her opponents are a squirrel in an odd outfit and three penguins.

Buddy Fairchild: Whoa now! Easy there, missy. Mind pointin' that popgun o' yers, well, at any other place than at me? Round where I'm from, it ain't seen as good manners.

Buddy Fairchild: Also—though I ain't accusin'—the shootin' of these here defenseless penguins would be a vi-o-lation of animal welfare law!

Moldir allows the barrel to drop but keeps a firm grip.

Moldir: I appreciate your attempt to defuse the situation.

Moldir: But I don't take species into consideration when it comes to assessing threats.

Moldir: So you have one minute to explain who you are and what you're doing here.

Buddy Fairchild: Come on now. We ain't fixin' to do ya no harm!

Moldir doesn't budge. Her eyes flick to her watch.

Penguins: Wawk wawk wawk!

Buddy Fairchild: I know, I know, Jake. Keep yer britches on. I'm handlin' it!

Buddy Fairchild: So, uh, what was it ya wanted? Name and purpose? No trouble at all.

Penguins: The squirrel raises a paw and points to each penguin in turn.

Buddy Fairchild: Ya got Fluffy Duke there, then we got Scarlet Titan, and ya already met Brother Jake. Just hopped off a plane from Miami, believe it or not—back in the ol' homeland ya see.

Then he points to himself with a tiny paw.

Buddy Fairchild: Oh, and I'm Buddy. Buddy Fairchild, if yer bein' proper. Squirrel arcanist from Florida in the good ol' US of A, and somethin' of what ya might call an "animal rights activist"!

Moldir tilts her head, trying to make sense of the bizarre situation.

Moldir: An animal rights activist ... So, what—you're here to protect the penguins?

Buddy Fairchild: Sure as grits is groceries. Someone's gotta look out for these fellas. So, whaddya say? Will ya do me a kindness and put that boomstick away?

Buddy Fairchild: Though, a word to the wise. There's a whole mess o' creeps prowlin' round out there in the snow.

Buddy Fairchild: All masked up and greasy as a fried egg. You caught us attemptin' to "exfiltrate the sit-chu-ation" as they say in the manuals.

Buddy Fairchild: Now, I was raised with manners, so I do apologize for bargin' in on ya. But time's almost up, and I said my piece. Ya still fixin' on sendin' us to our maker?

Moldir: Last question. How did you manage to sneak into my camp without making a sound?

Buddy Fairchild: Oh, it weren't no real trouble, seein' as we're just a handful o' penguins and a squirrel.

Buddy Fairchild: Not to put too much mustard on it, but ... humans're always underestimatin' us animals. There's a whole lotta places you folks wouldn't think to look on this big ol' ice cube.

Buddy Fairchild: Cracks in the glaciers, hollow snow pockets, volcano vents ... that sorta thing. Give us a little wiggle room, and we can squeeze in juuust about anywhere.

Penguins: Wawk wawk!

Buddy Fairchild: Yeah, I hear ya, Jake. You'll have to pardon my pal's anxiety, missy. He ain't all that used to havin' a gun trained on him.

Buddy Fairchild: Oww, and now this ol' headache is poundin' somethin' fierce. Now where in the heck did that come from?

The lieutenant studies the snow where the creatures had emerged. Faint, narrow holes beneath the surface hint that the squirrel is telling the truth.

At last, she eases up and stows her weapon.

Moldir: Those "masked creeps" you mentioned you were evading, do you know if they're operating close to this area?

Buddy Fairchild: Hard to say.

Buddy Fairchild: What with all the shortcuts we been takin', I couldn't say for certain where we last caught sight of 'em.

Penguins: Wawk wawk wawk!

Buddy Fairchild: Pree-cisely, Duke. Now, we just came down off them glaciers over yonder, and climbin' 'em was a nightmare and a half. But if you can navigate the volcanic vents, I'd say ya could make it there in under half an hour.

The lieutenant looks over to the military map beside her. A few quick calculations are enough to pin down the area the squirrel is describing.

Moldir: If that's the place you mean ...

Buddy Fairchild: Hey, missy, I gotta say—

Moldir: Lieutenant. Lieutenant Moldir.

Buddy Fairchild: Heavens to Betsy, o' course! Shoulda known a lady o' yer caliber'd be an officer.

Buddy Fairchild: And a lieutenant, no less! Hah! I salute you! Now, uh ... I hate to interrupt whatever it is we're interruptin', but we could use a teeny-tiny bit o' help.

The squirrel clutches his head with both paws and gives it a shake.

Buddy Fairchild: Like maybe somethin' to fix this goshdarn headache o' mine?

Moldir: We don't carry veterinary meds in our field supplies.

Buddy Fairchild: Hey!

Moldir: Your body's too small. A human dose could be dangerous.

Buddy Fairchild: Oh.

Buddy Fairchild: I beg yer pardon, Lieutenant. Didn't mean to take ya for the uncharitable type.

The squirrel shifts awkwardly, suddenly embarrassed by the turn of events.

Moldir: Come with me. My team is resting, so please keep quiet.

Buddy Fairchild: Where we goin'?

Before he can wrap his head around things, the squirrel finds himself trailing behind the lieutenant, penguin friends in tow.

Moldir: Let me do a basic checkup. I've had some emergency medical training.

Buddy Fairchild: Why, that'd be mighty kind o' ya, Lieutenant. Ya know, yer the only halfway-decent human I met since settin' paw in Antarctica.

Moldir: I appreciate the compliment ... Have you run into many other humans out here?

Buddy Fairchild: Just those oily, masked-up whackadoos!

Moldir: ... You really shouldn't have come here.

Buddy Fairchild: Yer tellin' me! This place is colder 'n the look ya gave me when I barged in this place! Heh, sorry again 'bout that. But ... well, look at 'em—

He points a paw toward the Adélie penguins waddling behind him.

Buddy Fairchild: I can't abide cruelty, and keepin' these cute lil fellas locked up under the Miami sun? Well, that's cruelty in its purest form!

Buddy Fairchild: I tried askin' nice, but them folks at the Foundation'd just wag their chins and say, "We're aware," then sit on their bee-hinds and do squat all about it.

Buddy Fairchild: Well, fine, I guess they don't care, but I do! So, I did somethin' about it.

Moldir's steps slow, the crunching snow suddenly feeling heavy underfoot.

Moldir: Miami, the Foundation, a zoo, and a squirrel ...

Moldir: I feel like I've heard of you before.

Buddy Fairchild: I sure hope so! I didn't get my mug plastered on wanted posters in every zoo from Pensacola to Key Largo by flyin' under the radar.

Buddy Fairchild: Big ol' red X right through my face. Classy, ain't it?

The lieutenant can't help but smile at the vivid description.

But her expression changes when she notices the squirrel has stopped walking. His beady black eyes lock onto her, and an all-too-human panic creeps across his fuzzy little face.

Buddy Fairchild: Oh my stars! Lieutenant, yer face ... why's it leakin' black goo?!

Moldir freezes. Her hand instinctively moves toward her backup sidearm—the one she chambered a round in the moment she stepped onto Antarctic soil.

An Opportunity

COL-312104

An Opportunity

The squirrel flails his paws and waves the penguins behind him into formation.

Buddy Fairchild: Get behind me, fellas! You see that there? That mask ... she's growin' a mask!

Penguins: Wawk?

Moldir: ...

Moldir's olive-green eyes widen. She reaches up and touches her own cheek.

Buddy Fairchild: Back off! I'm warnin' ya! Don't go underestimatin' me and my pals; we'll whip ya like fresh cream on a pecan pie!

Moldir: ... Will you really?

She glances behind her. The penguins are gone. Then she lets out a slow, steady breath.

Moldir: ... Delirium?

Penguins: Wawk wawk!

Calculating just the right force, Moldir chops the squirrel cleanly on the back of the neck.

Buddy Fairchild: Whoaa!

Buddy comes to, blinking under a steady light. He's strapped to a wooden table with a belt, his arms and legs pinned.

All around him are sinister tools and vials of mysterious liquid.

Buddy Fairchild: Oh no ...

Buddy Fairchild: Lieutenant! And here I thought you might be one o' the good'uns.

Buddy Fairchild: I shoulda known better than to trust a human. So, what're ya gonna do to me? Taxidermy? Die-section?

He hears the crunch of combat boots approaching. Then, those same calm, olive-green eyes hovering above his line of sight.

Moldir: Based on my knowledge of arcanum, a dissected squirrel wouldn't produce any valuable materials.

Buddy Fairchild: Hold yer horses ... ya can't just go sayin' I ain't got no value. I'm an arcanist just like you, remember?! Show a little respect!

Moldir: Tell me, what were the names of those emperor penguins you came with?

Buddy Fairchild: Names? Wait, what ... hey! Get it right, missy! They ain't no emperors! They're Adélie penguins!

Moldir: Correct. You passed.

The lieutenant loosens the straps binding him to the table. The fuzzy little arcanist springs upright, eyes darting around the room.

Penguins: Wawk wawk wawk wawk!

Buddy Fairchild: Thank my lucky stars, yer all still here!

Penguins: Wawk wawk wawk! Wawk wawk wawk!

Buddy Fairchild: Whaddya mean I went "off the rails" again?

Moldir: Then this must not have been your first episode.

Buddy Fairchild: 'Fraid so. All started when I ran into them gooey whackadoos; feels like I stumbled into a curse o' sorts.

Moldir: After you saw them ...

Moldir looks lost in thought for a second, then snaps back to the present and picks up the nearby med kit.

Moldir: I've already patched up the penguins. Now it's your turn.

Buddy Fairchild: Thank you kindly, Lieutenant.

Buddy Fairchild: I did say ya were the first good human I met since coming to Antarctica, now didn't I?

Moldir: You did. About five minutes before you accused me of being one of those masked people and tried to bite me.

Buddy scratches behind his ear, avoiding her gaze.

Buddy Fairchild: Don't rightly know what came over me back there. But the penguins say I been like this for a while now ...

Buddy Fairchild: Ramblin' 'bout stuff that don't make a lick o' sense, shadowboxin' with the air ... you get the idea.

Buddy Fairchild: Whoaa!

Moldir: Too rough?

Buddy Fairchild: Nope! Didn't feel a thing!

Trying to shift the mood—or distract from the pain—he changes the subject.

Buddy Fairchild: So, what unit ya with, Lieutenant? Thinkin' I oughta send a thank-you letter 'round when I get outta this mess.

Moldir: ...

Buddy Fairchild: Oh. I done stepped in it, haven't I?

Buddy Fairchild: Fair enough. Thinkin' if yer whole squad's out here in the coldest armpit of Antarctica, you gotta be on some kinda tip-top secret mission.

Moldir: I'm glad you get it.

Buddy Fairchild: So you ARE on a secret mission? Hoo-ee. That's sure excitin'.

Buddy Fairchild: You done me a real kindness, missy. If'n ya ever need a favor, just say the word. Yer pal Buddy Fairchild'll be there.

Moldir: A favor?

Moldir checks her watch again—four hours left before her team's scheduled rest break is over.

Moldir: If I had four search-and-rescue teams ...

The tempting thought makes her size up the squirrel a little more carefully.

Fluffy dark coat. Obvious in the snow. A rambunctious, slightly deranged, talking rodent from Florida she's known for less than an hour.

She can't just entrust a life—maybe even more than one—to chance.

Buddy Fairchild: Come ooon, let me help ya out! Y'know, I coulda been soakin' up the sun in the best waitin' room in the world, but here I am, in the blisterin' freeze-yer-butt-off cold with my penguin pals.

Moldir: So ... you crossed half the planet just to bring these penguins back home?

Buddy Fairchild: Well, don't give me too much credit. I weren't fixin' to be a hero or nuttin'—I was just the only one willin' to help.

Moldir: Are you friends now?

Buddy Fairchild: 'Course we are! More 'n that, we're a team!

Energetic, fearless, and full of heart. Loud, bold, and with a keen sense of justice.

The lieutenant gives a thoughtful nod. The fluffy little interloper has no idea he's just passed another one of her tests.

Moldir: I appreciate the offer, and I do need another pair of eyes, but give me a little time to plan some routes and make a few decisions.

Buddy Fairchild: Don't ya worry one lick about it. Yer right not to make any big decisions on the fly.

The squirrel tilts his head bashfully as the lieutenant speeds up her bandaging and packs her gear away.

Buddy Fairchild: So, what sorta dee-cisions we mullin' over?

Moldir: If we're going to work together, I need to determine what our plan of action looks like. You and your friends should feel free to rest here. I'll be back soon.

She's promising more than the rules allow. But she knows she can handle it.

A Cooperation

COL-312105

A Cooperation

29 hours after Andrea's team went missing.

Their rest has ended an hour early; the sergeant stands over a freshly drawn map with a look of genuine relief.

Squad Outpost

Sergeant White Gloves: We can widen the search range by at least 30 percent. At this rate, we might actually make it in under 36 hours.

Moldir: Assuming my numbers hold up.

Sergeant White Gloves: Everyone here trusts your judgment, Lieutenant.

Moldir: Yet, I have the sense you have more questions.

Sergeant White Gloves: Yes.

Sergeant White Gloves: Who are you counting on to be the fourth rescue team? Ptolemy's infantry won't arrive this fast, and Danilov's still grounded.

Moldir: Correct.

Sergeant White Gloves: Oh ... don't tell me we're working with ...

He mouths the word without saying it aloud.

Moldir: That's what I wanted to discuss with you, Sergeant.

Moldir: Whether or not we should, in this extreme case, accept help from ... an arcane animal.

Sergeant White Gloves: An arcane animal?

The sergeant chews on the strange phrase like frozen rations.

Sergeant White Gloves: Like a dog?

Moldir: A squirrel, actually ... plus three Adélie penguins.

Sergeant White Gloves: ... A squirrel?

His brow draws together.

Sergeant White Gloves: So, some mysterious, as yet unverified creature just shows up in camp, and you want to work with it?

Moldir: I wouldn't call him entirely unverified.

Moldir: I believe I've heard of him ... and I believe you have too, Sergeant.

Sergeant White Gloves: I think I would remember an "arcane squirrel" ...

Moldir: One of last year's "Lunch Hour Legends." I remember seeing you there. Then again, maybe you just didn't catch that part.

A flicker of recognition crosses the sergeant's face.

Sergeant White Gloves: It's been a while since we've had one of those ... since—

His train of thought stops short. Moldir's face remains still and cold.

Sergeant White Gloves: Yes ... I think I remember now. But can we trust it? This squirrel?

Moldir: I don't know.

Moldir: But time's running out ... I can't afford to turn down a chance to save them.

Her voice softens, emotion breaking like ice under her cold exterior.

But she doesn't let the cracks spread.

Moldir: There's a more crucial detail I need to share with you. I will inform the others later.

Moldir: If this squirrel—and the intel he's provided—can be trusted, we will need to prepare for something extra.

Sergeant White Gloves: Like what?

She doesn't answer right away. Her eyes narrow, weighing each word like she's walking a tightrope.

Moldir: Potential psychological disturbances, delirium, and ...

She looks down at a dark, handprint-like mark on the map. Her lips move, but no sound comes out.

The mood inside the tent grows dark.

Sergeant White Gloves: A lunchtime anecdote isn't enough to convince me. I don't support involving unknown people—or animals—in our operations, Lieutenant.

Moldir: I believe him to be a creature of noble character, Sergeant.

He shoots her a look of open disbelief.

Sergeant White Gloves: Noble character? I'm sorry, ma'am, but it's a squirrel.

Moldir: A squirrel that traveled over 8,000 kilometers to the South Pole to rescue three ordinary penguins.

Sergeant White Gloves: So what? Would you put David on the same level of value as a zoo animal? We can't put him at risk based on the confidence of penguins. 8,000 kilometers may be a lot, but I'd wager anything our people would do the same for David.

The lieutenant gives no reply, only pressing her lips into a thin, tight line.

Makeshift Clinic, Squad Outpost

Buddy Fairchild has no idea that a serious conversation is unfolding involving him.

He sprawls comfortably in his cozy pile of penguins, nuzzling into their soft feathers and fur, just like the good old days.

Buddy Fairchild: Ya know what, pals? I can't abide just waitin' here, sittin' around on my bee-hind.

Buddy Fairchild: It's just like the folks back at the Foundation, always makin' me wait—aw, heck ... they were just plumb ignorin' me, hopin' I'd wise up and get gone!

Buddy Fairchild: But I gotta feelin' this lieutenant's different. Lil icy on the outside, sure, but she helped us.

Penguins: Wawk Wawk?

Buddy Fairchild: Maybe I did get a little excited back there. But that don't mean we shouldn't be careful.

Buddy Fairchild: I won't put y'all at risk, ya hear? If she so much as thinks of askin' us for anythin' we ain't willin' to give, then we're outta here 'fore ya can say lickety-split.

Penguins: Wawk wawk wawk!

Buddy Fairchild: You said it, Fluffy Duke; runnin' away's what we do best!

The squirrel's ears twitch. Alerted to the sound of military boots crunching on snow.

Moldir: I hope you slept well last night, my friends.

Buddy Fairchild: That we did! Thanks again for the hospitality, Lieutenant.

Moldir: I can't offer you anything official. So I'm only asking this as a personal favor.

Buddy Fairchild: A favor?

Moldir: We're searching for a missing team. They've been out of contact for more than a day now, and we could really use your help, Mr. Fairchild.

Buddy Fairchild: Mister? Well ain't that fancy ... Alright, Mr. Fairchild it is.

The squirrel straightens up and circles the table's map on his tiny paws.

Buddy Fairchild: Lost in Antarctica, huh? That's one heck of a problem ya got on yer hands. Reckon you need someone who knows their way around the place.

Buddy Fairchild: Whaddya think, pals? The lieutenant and her friends could use a paw, and we do owe her one.

Penguins: Wawk wawk.

Buddy Fairchild: Glad to hear it! Lieutenant, you can count on us.

Moldir: I appreciate it.

Moldir: There may be danger, but I'll do everything I can to keep you and your friends safe. And I promise I'll push for formal recognition on your behalf.

The squirrel thumps his tail on the table, clearly impatient.

Buddy Fairchild: We'll get to that later. The important thing's that yer folks're in trouble, and we best get movin' to save 'em.

A Promise

COL-312106

A Promise

Plains, Antarctica

Given the risks ahead, Moldir reorganizes her scouting teams before departure.

Moldir: Do you think this would be the right heading?

Penguins: Wawk!

Buddy Fairchild: Scarlet Titan just swore on his belly fluff that it's the best way forward, Lieutenant, and don't nobody know Antarctica better 'n a penguin.

Buddy Fairchild: Will the rest o' yer soldier pals catch up to us? Ol' Jake could carry 'em a message if ya like.

Moldir: Let's press forward a little more. How far is the camp you mentioned?

Moldir: It's not that I don't trust you. But out here, every order has to be made with extreme caution.

Buddy Fairchild: No offense taken, Lieutenant. I getcha, believe me—I do.

The squirrel nods enthusiastically, spreads his paws, and rolls his eyes. It was a dramatic display for a human, let alone a squirrel.

Buddy Fairchild: See that there iceberg up ahead? We'll circle 'round it. Then there won't be no missin' their camp—thing sticks out like a gator in a henhouse.

Moldir: Thank you for understanding, Mr. Fairchild.

She glances down at her watch. 33 hours since David went missing.

Still not fully sure of the trust she's put in these new fuzzy companions, Moldir steps out on their fourth and newest search.

The one most likely to lead to an encounter with Manus Vindictae.

Moldir: I wanted to thank you again for your help and the risks you're taking.

Buddy Fairchild: Shucks, lieutenant. No need for none o' that.

Buddy Fairchild: We wouldn't be safe out here all on our lonesome neither. We're grateful for the backup.

Moldir: Hopefully, it won't be necessary.

The trek across the icefield is as grueling as it is dull. But Moldir is used to long marches and forges ahead at a steady, focused pace.

Buddy Fairchild: Soooo ... you got any funny stories or somethin', Lieutenant?

Moldir: Best to save our energy.

Buddy Fairchild: Oh, okay ...

Moldir: I'm sorry. I don't have much to say for now. Perhaps once we are in a safer spot.

Buddy Fairchild: Safer spot? You got one o' those? Wouldn't happen to be one o' them places with unlimited drink refills, would it?

Buddy Fairchild: Didn't expect to feel so parched with all this water around me, even if the whole lot's frozen ... Suddenly Florida don't seem so bad.

Buddy Fairchild: By the way, Lieutenant, where exactly did ya say ya heard o' me?

He's asking for a second time, seemingly probing. The lieutenant finds herself staring at her hand. Once, the warm winds of São Paulo had wrapped around that very palm the way cold wind and sub-zero-rated gloves do now.

Moldir: You were in the papers. I ... just remember hearing about you.

Buddy Fairchild: That figures.

Moldir: I believe it was in the "Oddities of the Americas" column.

Buddy Fairchild: Hmm ... well, famous is famous as far as I see it, dontcha think?

Penguins: Wawk wawk!

The mood shifts, and Moldir stiffens. Even Buddy seems to turn oddly serious.

Buddy Fairchild: This is the place.

Former Zeno Sentinel Unit Station

Scattered gear and supplies untouched but clearly abandoned to the elements. The chaos paints a grim picture.

After confirming the markings on the crates, Moldir pulls out her notebook and scrawls three short encrypted messages. She then hands them out to the three penguins.

Moldir: Thank you. Just drop these at the designated points.

Buddy Fairchild: You got it, Lieutenant. They'll have it done in a jiffy.

Buddy Fairchild: So ... what next?

Moldir's eyes flick across the map. Her steno pencil scratching the paper.

Moldir: We don't have much time. I need to ask for your help again.

Moldir: It's only a request—you can say no. It may be dangerous.

She glances back to her hand before meeting the squirrel's eyes with heartfelt resolve.

Moldir: No matter what you decide, you've earned my friendship.

Moldir: I promise, when the time comes, I'll do everything I can to keep you and your penguins safe.

Moldir: And even if I can't keep that promise myself ... my comrades will. I swear it, on a soldier's honor.

Buddy Fairchild: ... Whaddya mean, "if ya can't keep it"?

Buddy Fairchild: What's got ya thinkin' it'll be so dangerous?

Moldir: I don't know for sure. I'm simply preparing for the worst. It's something we always do before going into battle.

Buddy Fairchild: Ah, well ... ahem ... thank you then. That sure means a lot.

Buddy Fairchild: But ... ya did say I could say no, didn't ya?

The lieutenant nods and takes out a document.

Moldir: Can you read maps? Wait for Sergeant White Gloves at this location, and he'll handle everything from there.

Buddy Fairchild: But what about you, Lieutenant?

Moldir checks her watch, then looks across the snowfield cloaked in the shadow of a distant iceberg.

Moldir: I have orders. I need my team back.

Buddy Fairchild: In that case ... good luck, Lieutenant.

She nods her thanks, leaves a marker behind at the abandoned camp, and walks off into the white alone.

The squirrel watches her go, holding the papers she left.

Buddy Fairchild: There she goes ... that, my penguin pals, is a true hero, headin' out alone to save her kin.

Buddy Fairchild: And here I am, nuttin' but a squirrel with the tongue and mind to talk to animals ... ain't even got so much as a clue as to what those masked-up oil-spewers're sayin'.

Buddy Fairchild: But shoot—if not Antarctica, where in the world else would we go?

He stares down at the papers in his paw again.

Buddy Fairchild: Hmph! She called me "mister," dangnabbit!

He drops the papers and darts off after her.

A Betrayal

COL-312107

A Betrayal

34 hours after Andrea's team went missing.

Deep in Antarctica

There is now 1 hour and 17 minutes left until the lost team reaches the 36-hour threshold of dangerous exposure.

Moldir: Keep low, Mr. Fairchild.

The squirrel has no choice but to bury his colorful tail in a snowbank.

Buddy Fairchild: Sure wish I was like one o' them color-changin' octopuses ... then I could just show up in Antarctica and poof—blend right in like sugar in a salt shaker!

Buddy Fairchild: You know, Lieutenant, Brother Jake freezes fish like this—catches 'em and sticks 'em straight into the snow. Just like that.

Moldir: ... Frozen fish?

Buddy Fairchild: If we make it outta this, I'll be sure to have ya try it.

Moldir: Watch out!

A snowbank explodes under the shockwave of an arcane skill. Luckily, Moldir scoops up the squirrel just in time.

Buddy Fairchild: Oh my stars ...

Manus Believer: ㄕˊ ㄇㄊˋ ㄖㄅˊ ㄗㄞˋ ㄋㄚˋ ㄌㄧˇ

Moldir: ...

Moldir: Andrea?!

Andrea: Lieutenant. Thank goodness.

Moldir: Andrea ... your face ...

Buddy Fairchild: He's wearin' one o' them masks!

Moldir: I see it ... I see.

Andrea: You've awoken too, haven't you, Lieutenant?

Andrea: The Mother of Resurrection's call grows stronger here. I've already passed the trial.

Andrea: Join us, Lieutenant.

Moldir: Andrea ...!

Buddy Fairchild: Now wait just a second ... you two know each other?!

Andrea: All of it was a lie. A mistake. Twisted truths—!

Andrea: You've all been deceived. All things are lies and falsehoods ... except for THEM. Only the Mother of Resurrection holds the truth!

Moldir: Where are the others? Where's David?

Andrea: David?

Andrea: He has not yet passed the trial. But I'll soon help him.

Andrea: I'll help everyone. The Mother will save us all! Don't you want the truth, Lieutenant? The truth for arcanists like us?

Moldir: You betrayed us, Andrea.

Andrea: Come with me! David will be safe once he joins the Mother. THEY will heal him!

Andrea: They're all blind to the lies. They don't understand! We arcanists have no future unless we embrace the Mother of Resurrection!

Andrea: THEY are the true power in this world! Even Admiral Igor realized that. That's why we left Zeno in the first place—

A wisp of smoke curls from the barrel of Moldir's gun. Andrea stares at the steaming hole in the snow near his feet, stunned.

Moldir: That was a warning. I won't miss next time.

The lieutenant's chest heaves with rapid breaths.

Moldir: You betrayed your honor and everything you believed in.

Buddy Fairchild: You left Zeno?!

Moldir: ...

Buddy Fairchild: Now you wait just a hot minute, Lieutenant! I believe you owe me an explanation! How come yer best buds with this "mask man," huh?

Moldir: Things have not gone as intended.

She looks straight at the mask on Andrea's face. Thick, black fluid oozes from his eye sockets, like the tears of a true believer kneeling before their god.

She closes her eyes for a moment.

Moldir: Mr. Fairchild, listen to me. I will explain all of this. Just ... not now.

More Manus believers start to close in.

Moldir: We need to fall back. There's a weak spot in the encirclement to the rear left. You lead the way.

Buddy Fairchild: Whoa, whoa, whoa—just hold yer horses for a dang minute! I don't know my bee-hind from a biscuit right now! Are you two on the same team or not?!

Moldir: On the count of three. I need you to guide us out.

Moldir: One.

Andrea: Even after witnessing a miracle with your own eyes, you still won't believe?

Moldir: What I believe in is those I care for. Not some supposed god. I've already found someone I trust with my life.

Andrea: Even if he's already bowed before the divine?

The lieutenant shakes her head firmly. There is not a hint of doubt behind it.

Moldir: Three.

She scoops up the squirrel and darts through the gap in the circle. A blast of arcane energy erupts at her heels, staining the white of the ice field.

Thanks to her "Antarctic survival expert," they give the Manus believers the slip and make it back to the rendezvous point.

Squad Outpost

Sergeant White Gloves: Lieutenant, any updates?

Moldir: Bad news first. We haven't found David yet, but we know where he might be.

Sergeant White Gloves: I thought you said it was bad news.

Moldir: It gets worse. I found the rest of Andrea's team.

Sergeant White Gloves: And that's bad news ...? He was a good soldier, loyal and courageous. What happened?

She takes a deep breath, searching for the right words. But the squirrel, thumping the ground with his back foot in frustration, doesn't hold back.

Buddy Fairchild: Nuttin' "happened," pal! Turns out yer loyal soldier's livelier 'n ever—'cept for the creepy mask, oil leakin' from his face, and the small matter that he's gone plumb crazy!

Sergeant White Gloves: A mask? No. That's impossible.

Despite his denial, his pale face betrays him.

Moldir can't find the words to reassure him. All she has to offer is a long and heavy sigh.

Moldir: That's the thing ...

Sergeant White Gloves: Was it just Andrea? Or are there ... others?

Moldir: It seems they were all with him except for David. I don't know whether he's safe ... but apparently, he hasn't passed their so-called "trial."

Sergeant White Gloves: Then there's still time to save him. We need to take action, Lieutenant.

Moldir takes a steadying breath, bracing against the sergeant's growing intensity.

Moldir: Calm yourself, Sergeant. We need a solid plan first—this is about doing right by David. We won't get a second chance.

Sergeant White Gloves: ...

Sergeant White Gloves: You're right, Lieutenant.

Moldir: Don't give in to frustration, Sergeant ... we still have plenty of moves to make; we just need to know the lay of the land.

Sergeant White Gloves: Understood.

The sergeant collects himself, offers a salute, and then departs.

Now, only the lieutenant and her still furious fuzzball of a companion remain.

Buddy Fairchild: I been near tearin' my tail off for waitin'! Now it's my turn to get some answers.

Buddy Fairchild: That was terrifyin'! And plain sneaky to boot, Lieutenant. I still can't barely wrap my noggin 'round it.

Buddy Fairchild: So what is it? Ya with them oil spewers or not?

Moldir's breath catches. Her first response is pure reflex.

Moldir: We're not with them.

Buddy Fairchild: I sure do hope that's true, Lieutenant. I ain't so certain I could look at ya the same way otherwise.

Buddy Fairchild: I figured we were on the same side. That we were pals.

Buddy Fairchild: And I wanna believe it still. But the way I see it, you two were havin' one heck of a chat back there.

It's rare to see Moldir look this shaken, perhaps not since the downpour in São Paulo.

She tries, in vain, to offer an explanation.

Moldir: It was just ... a temporary cooperation. To save lives.

Buddy Fairchild: Dagnabbit.

Buddy Fairchild: I knew you two were too chummy!

Moldir: I'm sorry.

Moldir: I never meant to deceive you. I just ... never found the right time.

Buddy Fairchild: Well, you said it, Lieutenant—deception, clear and simple! But Buddy Fairchild ain't no fool. I knew ya were pullin' the wool over my eyes—weren't no doubt about it.

Buddy Fairchild: We fought side by side, and you done a good turn for me and mine. Didn't ya even have one moment where ya thought you oughta tell me the truth?

Moldir blinks. Her lashes flutter against the stinging wind.

Buddy Fairchild: Like, how 'bout right from the get-go?!

Buddy Fairchild: Coulda shot me a quick "Hey Buddy, sorry, but we gotta work with these creepy oil-leakin' mask guys for a bit to save some folks!"

Buddy Fairchild: Then maybe—just maybe—I woulda understood!

Moldir: I think ... it wasn't because I didn't trust you. It's just ...

She tries to purse her lips, but the cold air has left them stiff and chapped.

Moldir: I still haven't accepted it myself.

The treasured photo presses against her chest. She closes her eyes and sees a flicker of orange flame in the dark.

Moldir: I didn't tell you because I couldn't accept it. I was ashamed. Even if that shame went against the orders I was given ...

Moldir: I ... I'm sorry.

Buddy has seen many an apology over the years, most of them good for nothing. This one, though—it touches somewhere deep.

Buddy Fairchild: ...

Buddy Fairchild: I accept your apology, Lieutenant—but this is the end of our arrangement.

A Friendship

COL-312108

A Friendship

Squad Outpost

Sergeant White Gloves: Lieutenant, I still don't think it's a good idea to just let that squirrel and his crew walk away.

Moldir: They've already done far more than we asked of them, Sergeant.

Moldir: Now, this so-called "trial" could begin at any moment. We need to be ready. I won't accept any more losses—I can't.

Moldir: There are a lot of Manus believers out there. We'll have to break through their lines if we want to have any chance of reaching David.

Moldir: It's also possible David's lost the ability to move or act on his own. We have to be fully prepared, and that includes adjusting the size of our rescue squad.

Sergeant White Gloves: Are we declaring war on Manus Vindictae?

Moldir's fingers brush lightly against the radio on her shoulder.

Sergeant White Gloves: I know we're going after David, but does the admiral know we're about to reignite a war?

Moldir: We can't abandon David ... the admiral would never let us, Sergeant.

Moldir: I believe that wholly. I have to believe that.

The sergeant doesn't argue; he only stands at attention.

Sergeant White Gloves: So, it's war.

Moldir: No. The admiral is trying to earn their trust. We can't compromise his operation.

Moldir: Our only objective is to bring David home.

Sergeant White Gloves: Then what IS the plan?

Moldir: For now, I'll draw their attention while you lead the squad in to rescue him.

Moldir: If I don't make it back, command of this unit transfers to you.

Sergeant White Gloves: What?!

Moldir: It's protocol, Sergeant. We need a solid fallback plan. Everyone on this mission is counting on us.

Penguins: Wawk wawk wawk!

A shrill cry cuts through their conversation, out of place in the icy stillness.

Sergeant White Gloves: The squirrel's penguins?

Moldir: It must be about Mr. Fairchild. This one is Scarlet Titan. I marked them so I could tell them apart.

Sergeant White Gloves: Hmph. You always did have a soft spot for animals.

Penguins: Wawk wawk wawk wawk wawk—

While Moldir cannot speak with animals, the look in the penguin's eyes gives her a pretty good guess.

Moldir: You need my help, don't you?

Penguins: Wawk.

Maybe it's the sincerity in her voice, but the penguin seems more at ease now.

It lifts one wing, revealing a colorful tuft of squirrel fur stuck to the tip.

Moldir: Begin preparations, Sergeant.

Moldir: I'll be back as soon as I can.

Sergeant White Gloves: Understood. But Lieutenant, are you really going after that squirrel?

Sergeant White Gloves: Antarctica's no place for a solo rescue. This is reckless.

Moldir: I gave him my word. It's the least I can do after everything he's done for us.

Moldir: Forgive me, Sergeant. I know my actions may put the team at risk, but this is about my honor as a soldier.

She takes the tuft of squirrel fur from the penguin's wingtip and nods in thanks. The penguin squawks twice and gestures for her to follow.

This is the second time Buddy Fairchild has woken up on this exact table. Though at least this time it feels like a relief.

Buddy Fairchild: Hey! Was that all just a nightmare?

Moldir: If you count delirium as a kind of nightmare ... then yes.

Buddy Fairchild: Good grief! Lieutenant, it's you! I thought I was imaginin' things.

Buddy Fairchild: Was that one o' yer arcane skills? Fixin' up all that shattered ice in a blink? Puts mine to shame.

Moldir: There are limits. Many things in this world can't be fixed.

Buddy Fairchild: Golly, but ya already fixed so much.

Moldir blinks slowly, weighing the words.

Moldir: Perhaps. But this ability has also made me greedy.

Moldir: Once you fix one thing, it's hard to stop yourself from trying to fix everything else, too. You just keep trying and trying, because there's always something to be fixed.

Buddy Fairchild: Oh, I getcha, Lieutenant. Heck, if I had that kinda power, first thing I'd prolly fix is my old oak's knotty trunk back home.

The squirrel shrugs, then suddenly catches himself, remembering he's supposed to be mad.

Buddy Fairchild: Just for the record ... ya may've saved my bee-hind, but that don't mean we're square!

Moldir nods as she arranges some vials.

Moldir: I suspect your delirium is linked to the Manus, those "masked freaks" you mentioned.

Moldir: There are reasons I can't explain everything, but fighting them may have been what triggered your condition.

Moldir: That's on me. You don't owe me anything.

Buddy's ears twitch. The logic is messy, but it sort of tracks.

Buddy Fairchild: Hmm ... I'd say it's you who owes me, but, either way ... I figure I should thank ya.

Buddy Fairchild: How 'bout a frozen fish?

Moldir: I appreciate the offer, Mr. Fairchild.

Moldir: And if I make it back in one piece, I will take you up on it.

Buddy Fairchild: "Make it back"? This mission of yers really that dangerous?

The squirrel weighs his anger and loyalty like acorns on a scale. After a beat, he makes a decision.

Buddy Fairchild: Well ... ya did help me, and I'm a squirrel o' my word. So, I s'pose I can help ya one last time.

Buddy Fairchild: As long as it don't involve teamin' up with those masked-up creeps, me and my penguin pals're in.

A new plan begins to take shape in Moldir's mind. Risk and reward race through her calculations. She hesitates.

Moldir: I do want your help, Buddy. But I can't share everything with you without compromising military intel. I hope you understand.

Buddy Fairchild: I getcha, I getcha ... Well then, let's make this fair. You tell me what ya can plus a lil somethin' in the way o' payment.

Moldir: Payment?

Buddy Fairchild: Nuts, scarves, a lunch ... I'll take anythin', Lieutenant, just so long as it means we're friends again.

The squirrel scratches his ear, seemingly uncomfortable with talking payment.

Buddy Fairchild: Shoot ... I forgave ya the moment ya showed up. Maybe we can still be friends if ya give me another chance to help ya out.

She seems lost in thought. Buddy begins to sense he's been turned down, but before he can say anything, Moldir checks her watch.

Moldir: We're running out of time, so I'll keep this brief.

Moldir: For now, I'll draw their attention while you lead the squad in to rescue him.

Moldir: But we have to assume they aren't as mindless as they look. If we launch a second wave after our initial distraction, the sergeant's chances of getting in and out unnoticed are much better.

Moldir: It's dangerous, and while I'll handle the riskiest part ... I could use your help.

Buddy Fairchild: Hmm ... sounds like a tough nut to crack.

Buddy Fairchild: Lemme see ... I'm gonna need at least a whole bag o' trail mix, a fancy dinner with iced fish, and ... aha! A military rank. How does "Captain Buddy Fairchild" sound to ya?

Buddy Fairchild: Shouldn't ya be salutin' me 'round about now?

Moldir: If I were recruiting, I'd have to check with my superior first.

Buddy Fairchild: Ah, don't sweat it ... I was only yankin' yer chain 'bout that anyway.

Moldir: Well, regardless of how this mission goes, I'll bring it up with my commanding officer. Though ... "Captain" may be beyond my power as a lieutenant. But, if you're willing, how does "Sergeant Buddy Fairchild" sound?

Buddy Fairchild: Sergeant Buddy Fairchild?

Buddy Fairchild: My momma'd be so proud!

A Soldier

COL-312109

A Soldier

41 hours, 25 minutes.

Over four hours past the safe rescue window, but still well within the absolute survival limit.

They administer a stabilizer to quiet David's feverish muttering. Once he settles, Moldir and Sergeant White Gloves step out from the makeshift infirmary.

Sergeant White Gloves: What's his condition?

Moldir: Delirium, high fever, mental disorientation ... It's hard to say if he's still capable of basic reasoning.

Sergeant White Gloves: ...

Moldir: At the very least, we got him back.

Moldir: We'll figure the rest out ... Father will find a way.

Sergeant White Gloves: How's your injury, Lieutenant?

Moldir: Just a few scrapes—not enough to warrant even an arcane potion. Nothing to worry about.

Moldir: You did well out there, Sergeant. If your team hadn't pulled off that stealth entry, this whole mission could've gone sideways.

The sergeant looks at her, an unusual flicker of disapproval in his eyes.

Sergeant White Gloves: You know what I'm thinking, Lieutenant.

Moldir: I'm just stating facts, Sergeant. And I'll say the same when I report this to Command.

Sergeant White Gloves: You mean it was an unauthorized mission, then.

Moldir pauses, weighing her answer. Then, she shakes her head.

Moldir: I don't believe the admiral would ever abandon one of his own.

Moldir: This isn't the kind of mission Command would reject. I do believe that.

Even a soldier as certain as Moldir needs a moment alone to steady her thoughts.

The liquid in her hip flask is almost gone. She lifts it to her lips and takes another slow sip.

Moldir: ...?

Moldir: Next time, I'd prefer you use the front door.

A squirrel pops halfway out of the ground and taps a paw against the nearby ice.

Buddy Fairchild: Requestin' entry, Lieutenant.

Moldir: ... Permission granted.

Buddy Fairchild: M-h-m.

The squirrel wriggles out of a hidden vent, dragging a frozen fish behind him.

Buddy Fairchild: Back in Florida, we Fairchilds go about celebratin' our victories by keepin' our promises.

Moldir: We don't have that custom in Zeno, but ... I like the sound of it.

A combat knife slices through the frozen fish. Rose-pink frost gleams along the blade's edge.

Moldir: You brought the food. You get the first taste.

Buddy Fairchild: Thank you kindly. To be honest with ya, I ain't never tried fish this way. Ain't exactly easy to make a fish popsicle under the Florida sun.

He picks up a sliver of fish in his paws and gives it a sniff.

Moldir: That makes two of us.

Buddy Fairchild: Well now, we got ourselves some food and a bit o' peace and quiet. All we're missin' is a good story. So, who's goin' first?

The scene feels oddly familiar. Moldir's breath is steady, her posture calm. She draws in the crisp, chilly, and tasteless air.

It's so different from the air in São Paulo—warm, floral, bursting with life.

Moldir: I've never been much good with stories, so I always offer to go first. That way the better storytellers can take over.

Buddy Fairchild: You mean to say ya got a decent storyteller 'round these parts? Where ya been hidin' 'em? I was startin' to think that icy-and-silent attitude came in a box with the uniform—what with you and the sergeant.

Ripples dance across her olive-green eyes.

Moldir: There used to be.

Buddy Fairchild: Aw, heck ... I'm sorry.

Moldir: No, it's alright. She ... she's probably doing well. I like to think so.

Moldir: She just ... left us.

Buddy Fairchild: That's good ... uh, I mean ... wait, why?

The lieutenant doesn't answer.

Instead, she slides a slice of fish into her mouth. It's icy and smooth, with a strange sweetness, like salty ice cream.

Moldir: Hm. Not bad—quite pleasant, actually. Thank you.

Buddy Fairchild: It is? Huh. I figured this'd be another one o' Jake's pranks.

He follows her lead and takes a bite. A moment later, his entire body shakes from head to tail.

Buddy Fairchild: Yikes! That near knocked the teeth clean outta my mouth!

Buddy Fairchild: Anyways, Lieutenant, you and I are friends now ... but I still don't hardly know a lick about ya! Come on, share a lil somethin' with me.

Moldir: Me?

The lieutenant falls into thought, as if she's just been handed a mission far more difficult than any battle.

Buddy Fairchild: Come on now, I know ya got a story to tell—or ten. Drinkin' all alone like that? Somethin's on yer mind.

Buddy Fairchild: Lucky for you, I happen to be the very best listener from Key West to the Panhandle. Yer secrets're safe in this lil noggin o' mine, and I got yer back. Believe you me!

She doesn't answer, and again he thinks for a second he may be getting brushed off, until Moldir points to a nearby ammo crate and gestures for him to sit.

Moldir: I'm afraid my story's not all that exciting. But I can tell you another; just know it's ... not cheery.

Buddy Fairchild: Fine by me.

Moldir: It's a familiar tale. A girl loses her family, finds a new one ... and then loses them again.

Moldir: Things she swore she'd never betray start slipping through the cracks. Things she couldn't afford to lose are suddenly gone, maybe for good.

Moldir: And our main character? Completely helpless. Drinks too much to numb the pain but still can't sleep.

Buddy Fairchild: Golly ... Yeah, that's a real tugger on the heartstrings.

Buddy Fairchild: So, what's this main character fixin' to do about it?

Moldir: Well ... when the sun comes up, she'll get out of bed, hitch the horses, and go right back to work.

Buddy Fairchild: Huh?! Ya mean ... instead o' leavin' it all behind, she's just gonna keep on workin' like nuttin' happened? She got nuts for brains or somethin'?

Moldir: It's her job. Her duty. Her mission.

Buddy Fairchild: So even luggin' around all that pain, she still gets up and pulls her share day after day?

The lieutenant takes another sip from her flask and nods.

Moldir: Yes. Even then.

Buddy Fairchild: Gee. I sure wish I could give that poor soul a word or two of advice.

Buddy Fairchild: Like maybe she oughta just be kinder to herself, ya know? Why not do somethin' she wants to do?

Moldir: Because what we want isn't always what's right. And besides, she chooses to believe. Believe in fate ... and in the one who shapes it.

Moldir: And now that she's given herself the whole night to process everything, it's time to do what needs to be done.

The lieutenant runs her fingers across her radio, then smiles.

Moldir: Thanks for listening. And for the fish. But now, I've got something important to take care of.

She picks up the radio and steps outside.

Buddy Fairchild: Hey! You ain't gonna just leave me here on my lonesome are ya ...?! Really ...

The squirrel grumbles and shrugs. Then, he notices the flask Moldir left behind.

He remembers what she said, that the main character "drinks too much to numb the pain."

Buddy Fairchild: Just one tiny sip ... she ain't gonna mind.

He tips the flask and drips a few crystal-clear drops onto his tail, then gives it a quick lick.

But the burn of liquor never comes. Instead, cool water soothes his throat.

Buddy Fairchild: Huh ... Figures.